Common Medicines for Everyday Problems

Adult Reference Guide (self-care and triage companion)

Important: This guide lists commonly used non-prescription options for adults, compiled from standard public guidance (for example NHS, MedlinePlus and WHO essential medicines information). It is general information, not a diagnosis or prescription. Doses are typical adult label doses. **Always follow your product label** and ask a pharmacist or doctor if you are pregnant, breastfeeding, have kidney, liver, stomach or heart disease, or take other medicines. Children need weight-based doses; ask a pharmacist or doctor.

Quick reference

Problem	First-line option	Self-care limit
Headache	Paracetamol (acetaminophen) or ibuprofen	3 days
Fever (adults)	Paracetamol	3 days
Sore throat	Throat lozenges plus paracetamol or ibuprofen for pain	5 days
Cough	Honey in warm water; dextromethorphan for dry cough (per label)	14 days
Common cold and runny nose	Rest and fluids; saline nasal spray; paracetamol for aches	7 days
Heartburn and acid reflux	Antacid (calcium carbonate or aluminium-magnesium) for quick relief; omeprazole 20 mg for frequent heartburn	14 days
Diarrhea (adults)	Oral rehydration solution (ORS); loperamide if no fever or blood	3 days
Constipation	Fiber (psyllium husk) and fluids; lactulose or macrogol if needed	7 days
Nausea	Small sips of fluid and ginger; dimenhydrinate for motion sickness (per label)	2 days
Minor cut or scrape	Clean water and a clean dressing; antiseptic cream is optional	3 days
Insect bite	Hydrocortisone 1% cream; cetirizine for itching	3 days
Rash or allergic itching	Cetirizine 10 mg or loratadine 10 mg; hydrocortisone 1% for small areas	5 days
Back pain or muscle strain	Paracetamol or ibuprofen; heat; staying active	7 days

Self-care limit means: if symptoms last longer than this, see a doctor.

Call emergency services now for: chest pain or pressure, difficulty breathing, fainting, seizure, signs of stroke (face drooping, slurred speech, sudden weakness), severe bleeding, vomiting blood, swelling of the face or tongue, suspected overdose or poisoning, or thoughts of self-harm. Do not treat these at home.

Detailed entries

Headache

Medicine	Headache: Paracetamol (acetaminophen) or ibuprofen
Adult dose	Paracetamol 500-1000 mg every 4-6 hours, maximum 4 g in 24 hours (some labels cap at 3 g; follow your product label). Ibuprofen 200-400 mg every 6-8 hours with food, maximum 1200 mg/day without a doctor.
Cautions	Do not take ibuprofen with stomach ulcers, kidney disease, NSAID-triggered asthma, blood thinners or in late pregnancy. Check cold and flu products for hidden paracetamol.
Self-care	Rest in a quiet room, drink water, eat regularly, limit screens and caffeine.
See a doctor if	Headache lasting more than 3 days, the worst headache of your life, stiff neck, fever with rash, confusion, weakness, or headache after a head injury (go to emergency care). Also see a doctor if it lasts longer than 3 days.

Fever (adults)

Medicine	Fever (adults): Paracetamol
Adult dose	500-1000 mg every 4-6 hours, maximum 4 g in 24 hours (some labels cap at 3 g). Ibuprofen 200-400 mg every 6-8 hours with food is an alternative if suitable.
Cautions	Avoid paracetamol in serious liver disease or regular heavy alcohol use. Do not combine with other paracetamol products.
Self-care	Drink plenty of fluids, rest, wear light clothing. Medicine lowers discomfort; it does not treat the cause.
See a doctor if	Temperature 39 C or higher, fever lasting more than 3 days, fever with stiff neck, rash, trouble breathing, confusion, or severe pain. Also see a doctor if it lasts longer than 3 days.

Sore throat

Medicine	Sore throat: Throat lozenges plus paracetamol or ibuprofen for pain
Adult dose	Lozenges as per label, usually one every 2-3 hours. Paracetamol or ibuprofen at the doses listed under Headache.
Cautions	Antibiotics do not help most sore throats (usually viral). They are only used when a doctor confirms a bacterial infection.
Self-care	Gargle warm salt water, drink warm fluids, honey in warm water, rest your voice.
See a doctor if	Sore throat longer than 5 days, trouble swallowing or breathing, drooling, swelling of the neck, high fever, or white patches on the tonsils. Also see a doctor if it lasts longer than 5 days.

Cough

Medicine	Cough: Honey in warm water; dextromethorphan for dry cough (per label)
Adult dose	Honey 1-2 teaspoons in warm water, adults only. Dextromethorphan: follow the product label, usually 10-20 mg every 4 hours, not more than 120 mg in 24 hours.
Cautions	Do not use dextromethorphan with MAOI antidepressants or without asking a pharmacist if you take SSRIs. Cough suppressants are not for coughs with lots of phlegm.
Self-care	Warm fluids, steam inhalation, avoid smoke, keep the head raised at night.
See a doctor if	Cough longer than 14 days, coughing blood, shortness of breath, wheezing, chest pain, night sweats, or weight loss. Also see a doctor if it lasts longer than 14 days.

Common cold and runny nose

Medicine	Common cold and runny nose: Rest and fluids; saline nasal spray; paracetamol for aches
Adult dose	Saline spray as needed. Paracetamol at the doses listed under Headache.
Cautions	Antibiotics do not work on colds. Decongestants such as pseudoephedrine can raise blood pressure; avoid with hypertension or heart disease unless a doctor agrees. Do not use nasal decongestant sprays for more than 3 days.
Self-care	Warm drinks, steam, rest, wash hands often.
See a doctor if	Symptoms beyond 7 days or getting worse, facial pain with thick discharge, ear pain, high fever, or trouble breathing. Also see a doctor if it lasts longer than 7 days.

Heartburn and acid reflux

Medicine	Heartburn and acid reflux: Antacid (calcium carbonate or aluminium-magnesium) for quick relief; omeprazole 20 mg for frequent heartburn
Adult dose	Antacid as per label after meals and at bedtime. Omeprazole 20 mg once daily, 30 minutes before breakfast, for up to 14 days.
Cautions	Antacids can interact with other medicines; take them 2 hours apart from other tablets. Long-term acid suppression needs a doctor's review.
Self-care	Smaller meals, avoid spicy and fatty food, no food 3 hours before sleep, raise the head of the bed, reduce alcohol and caffeine.
See a doctor if	Trouble or pain swallowing, black or bloody stools, vomiting blood, unexplained weight loss, chest pain, or symptoms beyond 14 days. Also see a doctor if it lasts longer than 14 days.

Diarrhea (adults)

Medicine	Diarrhea (adults): Oral rehydration solution (ORS); loperamide if no fever or blood
Adult dose	ORS after each loose stool. Loperamide: 4 mg first, then 2 mg after each loose stool, maximum 8 mg/day without a doctor. Stop after 48 hours.
Cautions	Do not use loperamide if there is fever, blood or mucus in the stool, or for children. Dehydration is the main danger.
Self-care	Sip fluids often, eat bland foods (rice, banana, toast), avoid alcohol and milk-heavy foods briefly.
See a doctor if	Diarrhea longer than 3 days, blood in stool, high fever, severe stomach pain, signs of dehydration (very dry mouth, little urine, dizziness). Also see a doctor if it lasts longer than 3 days.

Constipation

Medicine	Constipation: Fiber (psyllium husk) and fluids; lactulose or macrogol if needed
Adult dose	Psyllium husk with a full glass of water as per label. Lactulose or macrogol as per label.
Cautions	Avoid regular use of stimulant laxatives (such as senna or bisacodyl). Take fiber with plenty of water.
Self-care	More fruit, vegetables and whole grains, 6-8 glasses of water daily, daily walking, do not ignore the urge to go.
See a doctor if	Blood in stool, severe stomach pain or swelling, vomiting, unexplained weight loss, or constipation longer than 7 days. Also see a doctor if it lasts longer than 7 days.

Nausea

Medicine	Nausea: Small sips of fluid and ginger; dimenhydrinate for motion sickness (per label)
Adult dose	Dimenhydrinate: follow the product label. It causes drowsiness.
Cautions	Do not drive after sedating antihistamines. Avoid alcohol with them.
Self-care	Small frequent sips of clear fluids, bland dry foods, rest, fresh air.
See a doctor if	Nausea beyond 2 days, unable to keep fluids down, severe stomach pain, blood in vomit, or pregnancy with severe vomiting. Also see a doctor if it lasts longer than 2 days.

Minor cut or scrape	
Medicine	Minor cut or scrape: Clean water and a clean dressing; antiseptic cream is optional
Adult dose	No oral medicine needed. Paracetamol at standard doses if painful.
Cautions	Check your tetanus vaccination status.
Self-care	Wash hands, rinse the wound under clean running water, press with a clean cloth to stop bleeding, cover with a clean dressing and change daily.
See a doctor if	Bleeding that does not stop after 10 minutes of firm pressure, deep or gaping cuts, dirt that cannot be removed, animal or human bites, or redness, swelling, pus or fever. Also see a doctor if it lasts longer than 3 days.

Insect bite	
Medicine	Insect bite: Hydrocortisone 1% cream; cetirizine for itching
Adult dose	Hydrocortisone 1%: thin layer 1-2 times daily for up to 7 days. Cetirizine 10 mg once daily.
Cautions	Do not apply hydrocortisone to broken skin or the face without advice. Cetirizine can cause drowsiness.
Self-care	Wash with soap and water, apply a cold compress, do not scratch.
See a doctor if	Swelling of the face, lips or tongue, trouble breathing, dizziness (emergency); spreading redness, pus, or fever. Also see a doctor if it lasts longer than 3 days.

Rash or allergic itching	
Medicine	Rash or allergic itching: Cetirizine 10 mg or loratadine 10 mg; hydrocortisone 1% for small areas
Adult dose	Cetirizine or loratadine: 10 mg once daily. Hydrocortisone 1%: thin layer 1-2 times daily for up to 7 days.
Cautions	Reduce the dose or ask a doctor if you have kidney disease (cetirizine). Do not scratch or use cream on infected skin.
Self-care	Moisturize, wear loose cotton, avoid known triggers and harsh soaps.
See a doctor if	Rash with fever, blistering, rapidly spreading rash, mouth sores, swelling of the face or tongue, trouble breathing, or rash beyond 5 days. Also see a doctor if it lasts longer than 5 days.

Back pain or muscle strain	
Medicine	Back pain or muscle strain: Paracetamol or ibuprofen; heat; staying active
Adult dose	Paracetamol or ibuprofen at the doses listed under Headache. Ibuprofen is taken with food.
Cautions	Rest for no more than a day or two; gentle movement heals faster. Same ibuprofen cautions as under Headache.
Self-care	Warm pack for 15-20 minutes, gentle stretching, light walking, good posture.
See a doctor if	Numbness or weakness in the legs, loss of bladder or bowel control, pain after a fall or injury, fever, or pain beyond 7 days. Also see a doctor if it lasts longer than 7 days.

General medicine safety

1. Read the label and use the lowest dose that works for the shortest time.
2. Never take two products with the same active ingredient (for example several products containing paracetamol).
3. Antibiotics are prescription medicines and do not treat colds, most sore throats or most coughs.
4. Tell your pharmacist about all medicines and supplements you take, and about pregnancy, allergies and long-term conditions.
5. Stop and get medical help if you develop a rash, swelling, trouble breathing, or symptoms that get worse.
6. Keep medicines out of reach of children and do not use them after the expiry date.

Review by a qualified pharmacist or doctor is recommended before using this document in any real health service.